per hectare to farmers every year, more than what they can theoretically earn today even if MSP is implemented all over the country for all crops.

Agriculture cannot provide an adequate income to the millions of farmers in India. At the time of Independence, about 70 per cent of workers were farmers and agricultural labourers. Now a little more than 50 per cent of workers are farmers. In absolute numbers, there are about three times more cultivators and agricultural labourers in 2011 compared to 1951, 26.3 crore as against 9.7 crore. Agricultural land has increased only by 15 per cent in this period.

This requires a lot of farmers to move into non-agricultural occupations. While this has been a work in progress, the pace has been quite slow. Government policies have discouraged the migration of agricultural labour to non-agriculture. However, migration of farmers to non-agricultural professions would have no adverse impact on agricultural productivity. Rather, it would be raised as it would lead to more mechanization and efficient operation of farm holdings.

Focused skill development programmes for farmers to equip them to work in construction, manufacturing and services would help this transition. Migrant-friendly policies, ample rental housing in urban areas and industry-led skilling programmes would make a vital difference.